
Reading Water

*The sheet that makes the other sheets
portable*

Why fish are where they are, so you can find them on any lake

Every numbered spot in this guide was chosen by the same reasoning, and once you can do that reasoning yourself you no longer need the numbers. Fish are not distributed evenly. They stack up wherever two things meet.

The one idea: fish live on edges

What an edge is	Any place where the water changes — shallow to deep, weed to open, hard bottom to soft, warm to cold, bright to shaded, current to still. An edge gives a predator cover on one side and hunting ground on the other, and it concentrates the food chain from the bottom up.
The best spots have two	A weed edge is good. A weed edge on a point is better. A weed edge on a point next to a fast drop into deep water is where everything in the lake eventually shows up. Pine Lake's mid-lake bar is four edges stacked in one place, which is why it is spot 4.
The featureless middle	A flat, uniform bottom in open water holds almost nothing. If you cannot name the edge you are fishing, you are probably not fishing anything.

The edges worth finding, in order

Edge	Why fish use it	On these lakes
Break (drop-off)	A fish can move between shallow feeding and deep safety without crossing open water. The steeper the break, the less distance that move costs, so steep breaks hold fish through more of the day.	Pine 3 (east wall), 8; North 3, 7
Weed edge	The outside line where weed growth stops for lack of light. Bait hides inside it, predators patrol outside it. In clear water it is deep; in stained water it is shallow.	Pine 5 at 12–18 ft; North 1 at 6–10 ft
Point	A finger of shallow ground reaching into deep water. It intercepts fish moving along a shoreline and it catches wind. Fish the <i>end</i> , not the sides.	Pine 2, 8; North 3
Bar or hump	Shallow structure isolated in deep water. The best of all, because it is the only cover for a long way and fish have to commit to it.	Pine 4; North 4
Inside turn	A notch where the depth line bends back toward shore. Fish moving along a break funnel into it.	Pine 2, 7; North 2
Neck or narrows	Anywhere a lake pinches. Everything that moves between two areas passes through, and current keeps the bottom clean.	North 5
Inlet / outlet	Moving water: different temperature, oxygen, and a constant delivery of food. First place to look in early spring and late fall.	Pine 9; North 2, 6
Wind-blown shore	Wind pushes plankton against a bank, then baitfish, then predators. Uncomfortable to fish, which is exactly why it is uncrowded.	Whichever side the wind is on
Shade line	The edge of a dock, an overhanging tree, a weed mat. A fish in shade sees out; you cannot see in. Midday, high sun.	Pine 6, 7; North 1

The invisible edge: the thermocline

What happens	By early summer a deep lake settles into three layers: a warm mixed layer on top, a thin band where temperature falls sharply — the thermocline — and cold, dense water below.
Why it matters	The layers stop mixing. Below the thermocline, oxygen is no longer being replenished. In most lakes that makes the deep water uninhabitable by midsummer, so <i>every fish in the lake</i> is squeezed into the water above it.
Pine Lake is the exception	It is deep and clean enough to keep oxygen in the cold layer, which is why it holds cisco. That means predators here have somewhere to go that most lakes do not — and in July and August they go there. <i>see the Cisco sheet</i>
How to find it	On sonar it is often a faint horizontal band of clutter. Or lower a thermometer: where the reading drops several degrees in a couple of feet, that is it. Typically 15–25 ft in this part of Wisconsin.
Turnover	In autumn the surface cools until the layers have the same density and the whole lake mixes. For a week or two the water looks cloudy and the fishing is genuinely poor. Then it is the best month of the year.

A method for a lake you have never seen

1. Look at a contour map *before* you launch and mark every point, bar, inside turn and narrows. That is your list of candidate spots and it costs nothing.
2. On the water, find the weed line first. It tells you how far light penetrates, which tells you how deep everything else will be.
3. Start shallow and early. Work out and down as the sun climbs.
4. Fish an edge, not an area. Keep the boat on one depth and follow it.
5. When you catch one, stop and note the depth, the bottom, and the edge. Then find the same combination somewhere else on the lake — fish are creatures of pattern, and the pattern repeats.

The point of the numbered spots

The nine spots on Pine Lake and the seven on North Lake are not secrets; they are worked examples. Each one is a named edge, and the lake sheets say which edge and why. Learn the reasoning and you can walk up to any lake in the county and produce your own list before you get the boat wet.

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